



On the back foot:

Rohit Sharma and Virat Kohli have been under scrutiny for their lean returns in recent months.

K. R. DEEPAK

All-round depth, spin heft and lefty firepower in focus

Shubman Gill retaining the **vice-captaincy over senior players** in the Champions Trophy squad signals a strong endorsement for his future as captain.

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Since winning the T20 World Cup in the Caribbean in June 2024, India has endured an underwhelming run of results. This has mounted pressure on coach Gautam Gambhir, who took over from Rahul Dravid after the World Cup, and skipper Rohit Sharma heading into the ICC Champions Trophy.

Can India's players get their act together and reinforce their

supremacy by winning this eight-team event?

While Rohit and Virat Kohli have been under scrutiny for their lean returns in recent months, the 50-over format may provide a conducive setting for the two stalwarts to free up and return to their best. If they hit their stride, along with Shubman Gill in the top three, India could dominate this tournament just as it did when hosting the 2023 ODI World Cup — until running into Australia in the final.

There is also plenty of firepower in the middle order, with Shreyas Iyer, Rishabh Pant, K.L. Rahul and Hardik Pandya all possessing the requisite skill to win matches with the bat.

Jasprit Bumrah's absence from the Champions Trophy is a major blow to India's chances. The 31-year-old, widely regarded as the best bowler in the world, has been ruled out due to a back injury. His presence would have given India a significant edge over its rivals. His ability to deliver in the